

It Takes 4 Months To Change Your Life - 1STMAN

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Executive Summary

Using the science of skill acquisition (20 hours to competence) and habit formation (21 days), you can learn 6 new skills, drop 6 bad habits, build 6 good habits, and reshape your body in just 4 months.

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The 20-Hour Rule: Becoming Competent at Anything 0:00

- The video was inspired by two things: viewer comments and a TEDx talk about skill acquisition
 - The speaker couldn't recall the presenter's name but said he'd try to link it in the description
- The commonly cited **10,000-hour rule** from Malcolm Gladwell's *Outliers* is about becoming an expert — not necessarily the goal for most skills
 - For a dedicated craft (film directing, a sport, your "one thing"), 20,000–30,000 hours may be warranted
 - But for everyday life improvement, expert-level mastery is usually unnecessary
- The TEDx presenter's finding: it takes **20 hours of focused, deliberate practice** to become *competent* at a skill
 - "Competent" = not the best, not satisfactory in a professional sense, but functional — able to get by and produce something credible
 - Example given: 20 hours of Photoshop gets you to the point where you can create an image people say "Yeah, that looks real. That looks good" — not Pinterest-worthy, but solid
- Key caveat: the 20 hours must be focused learning with no distractions — not passive or casual exposure

The Four-Month Math: 6 Skills, 6 Habits 1:59

- Most people working a 9-to-5 with relationships and other commitments still have **2–3 hours of spare time daily**

- The speaker believes everyone can carve out at least **1 hour per day** for learning and self-development
- At 1 hour/day of learning:
 - 20 hours = ~20 days to reach competence in one skill
 - In a 30-day month, that's roughly **1.5 skills per month**
 - Over **4 months (roughly 120 days)** = approximately **6 skills** you can become competent in
- Habit formation runs on a parallel timeline:
 - Research (referenced as the book *The Habit Loop*) suggests it takes **~21 days to build a new habit** and **~21 days to break an old one**
 - Over 4 months: **6 habits added + 6 habits removed**
- The combined result: 6 new skills + 6 new habits + 6 fewer bad habits = a fundamentally different person

"Six new great habits and six new skills — that's an unrecognizable person."



Skill Examples: What You Can Learn in 20 Hours 4:40

- **Language basics**
 - Strategy: focus your 20 hours exclusively on *connective/abstract words* — the ones you can't point to
 - Words like: here, there, how, why, where, what, and, those
 - These make up roughly **90% of conversation**
 - Concrete nouns (chair, phone, face, microphone, screen) are easy to learn on the fly because you can point to them or picture them
 - Abstract connectors have no image, so they're the hardest and most valuable to pre-learn
 - Result: you could go to any country, deploy those connective words, and point at everything else — functional communication from 20 hours of focused study
- **Coding**
 - Won't make you a world-class coder or able to build a full website from scratch
 - But 20 focused hours = competence to execute basic commands and build a basic website
- **Photoshop**
 - 20 hours = ability to produce credible, natural-looking images
- **Music production software**
 - 20 hours = very competent level based on the TEDx research
- **Filming / video production**
 - Same 20-hour framework applies
- **Podcasting / public speaking**
 - 20 hours of podcasting ≈ 20–40 episodes recorded
 - At that point: "You're going to be a good host right now"

- Key principle: **match the skills to what you want to achieve** — if you're building a business, pick skills that serve that goal directly

Physical Transformation: Gym, Face, and Lifestyle 3:07

- **Gym training**
 - Prescription: **6 days a week**, compound lifts followed by isolation lifts, eating clean
 - 4 months = ~120 days; missing only 1 day/week = a massive volume of quality training
 - Result regardless of starting point: "You're going to look fantastic" — better shape, stronger jawline, improved overall appearance
- **Mewing / orthotropics (face reshaping)**
 - Techniques: tongue on the roof of the mouth, chewing gum consistently to build jaw muscles
 - Muscles targeted: pterygoid muscle — adds a bump and roundness to the face
 - Benefits over 4 months: hollow cheeks, higher-looking cheekbones (possibly a couple of millimeters), more width and strength around the jaw and face
 - Speaker admits he'd been "lazy with it" but confirms the results from prior experience
- **Skin care**
 - Exfoliate regularly, apply natural moisturizers
 - Recommended products: natural, organic, unrefined butters — specifically **shea butter** and **avocado butter** (available on Amazon)
- **Sleep**
 - Getting quality sleep for all 4 months is listed as a core pillar alongside gym and diet
- **Grooming**
 - Getting a haircut, trimming up — part of the overall outer transformation
- **Alcohol**
 - Advised to cut it out during the 4 months; speaker acknowledges "it tastes very good" but frames it as a necessary sacrifice

Breaking Bad Habits and Building New Ones 9:16

- Timeline: **21 days to break a bad habit OR build a new one** (sourced from *The Habit Loop*)
- Six bad habits to eliminate (examples given):
 - Smoking
 - Alcohol
 - Masturbation and porn (NoFap)
 - Going to bed late / waking up late
 - Eating junk food
 - Excessive technology/screen use

- Six good habits to build (examples given):
 - Reading one book every ~20 days (finishing one per cycle)
 - Dedicated learning for 1 hour every day
 - Morning runs
 - Regular gym attendance
 - Saving and investing money
 - Getting quality sleep
- Important caveat: **addictive behavior changes this equation significantly**
 - For people with genuine addiction, breaking habits is "very, very tough" and the 21-day rule may not apply cleanly
 - Speaker uses himself as an example of non-addictive behavior: can drink heavily one night and not drink again for years
- Personal testimony: the speaker went through NoFap, gym, orthotropics, stopped going on nights out, stopped chasing women
 - "When you exchange those things... it only takes around about 4 months and then you're in a routine... it's part of who you are"

The Big Picture: What 4 Months Actually Gets You 10:28

- Speaker previously said 3 months; updated to **4 months** for being "a little bit more realistic" and allowing more time to achieve more
- Full summary of what's achievable in 4 months:
 - Learn **6 new skills** to a competent level
 - Build **6 new positive habits**
 - Break **6 old bad habits**
 - Get into great physical shape
 - Improve face structure via orthotropics
 - If starting a podcast: produce **~50 episodes**
- Frame it as a seasonal challenge: pick any 4-month window (e.g., June–September, September–December) and fully commit
- "People think that in order to become a successful man, you need like 10 years of effort. You don't. That just drains you."
- The first 3–4 months are the hardest and most transformative — once the routine is established, it becomes self-sustaining and easy to build on
- "Six things is enough to turn you from a bum to a successful man" — the compounding of skills, habits, and physical change makes the total transformation feel unrecognizable